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Chapter Six **JoFatema's** **Story**

I

What can I tell you about me? I have no identity and no story to tell. The villagers call me Crazy Fatema, but I am not a mad woman. Those who call me crazy are **the real crazy ones**, for they don't know what I've gone through.

I was named after our Prophet's daughter, Fatema. My grandmother always used to say

that I was the good luck charm of the family; after all, I was Fatema, the namesake of the most virtuous woman!

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Sheikh Mujib had declared Bangladesh a **free** country before he had been arrested. We also heard that the Pakistani Army had killed tens of thousands of innocent civilians in Dhaka.

Within a week, the impact of those horrendous incidents in Dhaka started to unfold in our village. The Biharis of Khalispur united and formed a militia force in support of **the** Pakistani government. They publicly announced that they would slaughter every Bengali dog in town. The college hostel became **empty as** students fled in fear. Young men and women boys and girls, old people, and **little** children started to run away to **escape** the wrath of the Bihari militants. My parents and my siblings ran too. I grabbed my six years old brother Pona and joined them. Pona was too weak and couldn't keep **pace**. So I picked him up and kept running. But Nasir Ali and his gang were quicker than me. They chased me and pinned me down. Nasir Ali snatched my little brother from me and thrashed him on **the** street. I heard Pona crying for help, and then I saw his skull break into pieces. My brother's brain jumped out of his tiny head and fell like a lump of blood on the pavement. Nasir and his team dragged me towards their housing estate. The militants had established their **headquarter** in their own housing complex.

Neelima, what can I say, Fatema died that night. The perversion that I saw in those people has shaken my very core values about the family and relationships. I lay on the ground like a slaughtered animal when Nasir Ali and his father took turns in raping me, and then handed me over to other men of their community. I saw another girl and her mother lying only a yard away from me. After they were done with me, Nasir Ali and his father took their turns in raping that girl and her mother. They laughed and hissed as they called us 'Bengali bitches.' I clearly remember women's voices cheering from somewhere as their men raped us. I don't think you have witnessed such incidents in your life, Neelima; well, how could you? You belong to the privileged class!

"I almost did, Fatema, but the Almighty saved me and my family."

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I wanted to be strong; I wanted to live till the day I could come back to avenge Pona's death by killing Nasir Ali.

We were kept in an army camp in Khulna for one or two months. Then they transferred us to Jessore Army Base. Twenty of us were dumped in a big hall room. The youngest among us was thirteen or fourteen; I was sixteen; the rest of them were between

seventeen to early forties. Soldiers in this barrack were cruel to the utmost extent. But still I thought they were somewhat better than Nasir Ali and his gang, who used to beat me constantly while violating my body. Nasir's people laughed their hearts out as I cried, begging them to show a little mercy. And when **my** throat went dry, I **cried** for a little drink of water; and you know what they did? **They** urinated in my mouth! Can you believe how cruel **a** man can **be** to piss on a girl's mouth when she cried for water? However, I later realized that my assessment about the Pakistani brutes was quite wrong; it turned out that I had just fallen from a frying pan to hell fire. These people were masters of perversion. Even the most learned psychologists would **have** failed to understand the **level** of sexual perversion these monsters had. One day, one of the soldiers attacked me in such a horrible way-I don't know how to tell you this-but I do think I should tell you, because people should know how much torture I had to endure for **the** sake of my country! This soldier was very cruel to everyone, and especially to me. For **some** reason, he couldn't stand me at all. Perhaps my hatred for him was too transparent. He would kick me or slap me on my head every time he walked by me.

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One night, as this beast approached me, I could see he was utterly drunk; and I thought a Muslim would **never** drink alcohol. But those 'pious' soldiers always drank, and so did their superior officers. That night, he attacked me like one ferocious monster. First he brutally raped me, and then he grabbed my head with his two hands and shoved his penis in **my** mouth. I took a deep breath and

bit him with all my strength. As my teeth sunk into his flesh, he gave out a howl like one injured animal and shoved me away.

The wounded **animal** grabbed a **piece** of cloth and tied my hair I with it. He then hung **me with the** ceiling fan **and** turned the switch on to its **fullest speed**. The **whole** world **was** swirling with **me** as I kept rotating with the **fan**, screaming and crying. Finally

someone came to turn the switch off, but I had no recollection of anything afterwards.

They took me to **the** hospital
where I lay

life as
unconscious for a while. It took me a **few** days to **recover**. After a few days, they sent **me** back to that barrack to resume my **their** courtesan. However, I **later came** to know **that the** soldier's cruelty had been reported to his superiors. He **was** court-martialled and sent back to Pakistan.)

We didn't know what **was** going on in **the** outer world. A

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Most were

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being relocated from one station to another and **they would come to** our bunker to have their farewell **sex** orgies.

There was a Hindu girl with us. Her name was Chapa. She **always** stood by the wall and tried to hear the sounds coming from the world outside. One day she said quite excitedly, "Fatema, come, listen with me, I can **hear** trucks coming in this direction. I n hear people chanting in Bengali. I followed her and placed **my** head on the wall. I did hear trucks, but they didn't stop at our

can

bunker.

"We will be free soon, Fatema! I am sure India is now attacking Jessore. India, as our ally, must have sent her soldiers to help us in the war. I am sure our brave

fighters will win. Then we

will be free.

FREE!"

"How do you know all these things, Chapa?"

I asked her.

"I am from a family of rebellious fighters in Barisal. I am from the village of Ashwini Datta and Mukunda Das. Have you heard of them?"

"Yes, I know about Ashwini Datta, but not that much." I felt embarrassed, "You know, Chapa, I am not that educated. I **was** about to start college when the ruffians abducted **me**."

"My father was a leader of the language movement in **1952**. He was in jail for eight years. My older brothers have gone to fight in the war. My parents gave their life trying to **save** me from the thugs. My little brother was also killed."

"I also lost a little brother," I told her, "Stay strong and have faith. I am sure you will go home one day."

"How can I go home, Fatema? There is no home for me. I am a Hindu woman, raped by Muslim soldiers-there is no home for me."

said.

"Then where will you go?"

"I will figure out how to survive in a free country." Chapa

Later that night, an officer came in and told us, "We have decided to let you free. So get up-and go."

We were frantic and

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brothers

prevented

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me from going to college. "You wouldn't be

able to handle the cruelty of people,

Fatema," they said, "the

townspeople

are

are insensitive and they will break your spirit

every

time they see you." I opted to sit for a

private **examination** and **earned** a

bachelor's degree from home. I started

looking for a job afterwards. I dropped

off my **resume** to schools and **private**

business offices, and went to meet

potential employers in every sector. But

everyone refused me jobs. The schools didn't want

to hire a woman with a reputation of my kind

simply because they felt I wasn't going to make

a good role model. **Private** companies considered my past a potentially **disruptive** element in the office environment. Heartbroken, I fell before my father's **feet**, "What will I do now, *Baba*? What is going to happen to me?" Father gave me courage and promised he would do his best to see **me** happy in life.

(My father **came up** with the safest solution, **marriage**

He wanted **me** to marry a man, any man from a **respectable** family. He was not going to look at the groom's education or economic condition; all he was looking for was a man of character a man who would love and respect me whole-heartedly. Taher appeared to be one such gentleman. He promised to take care of **me** through thick and thin. Taher was only a high school graduate, a self-made man. He lived in a small village, with his elderly parents. On our wedding night, I told him directly, "I want to make sure my father had told you about my past. I am a *Birangana*."

"I know," Taher replied, "and so do my **parents**, and **we** all respect you for that. I promise you I will never disrespect you. I will protect you from all adversaries of life."

Taher kept his promise. He never left me alone or unattended. He fulfilled my whims **and** tried his best to make me happy. My father-in-law found me a job **at the** local primary school. "Go, teach the young kids, but work for free. You don't need that money." I was grateful to my father-in-law for finding me that job. He knew I was depressed because I had nothing to do in the house. The job kept me

busy from morning **to** afternoon. Then Taher